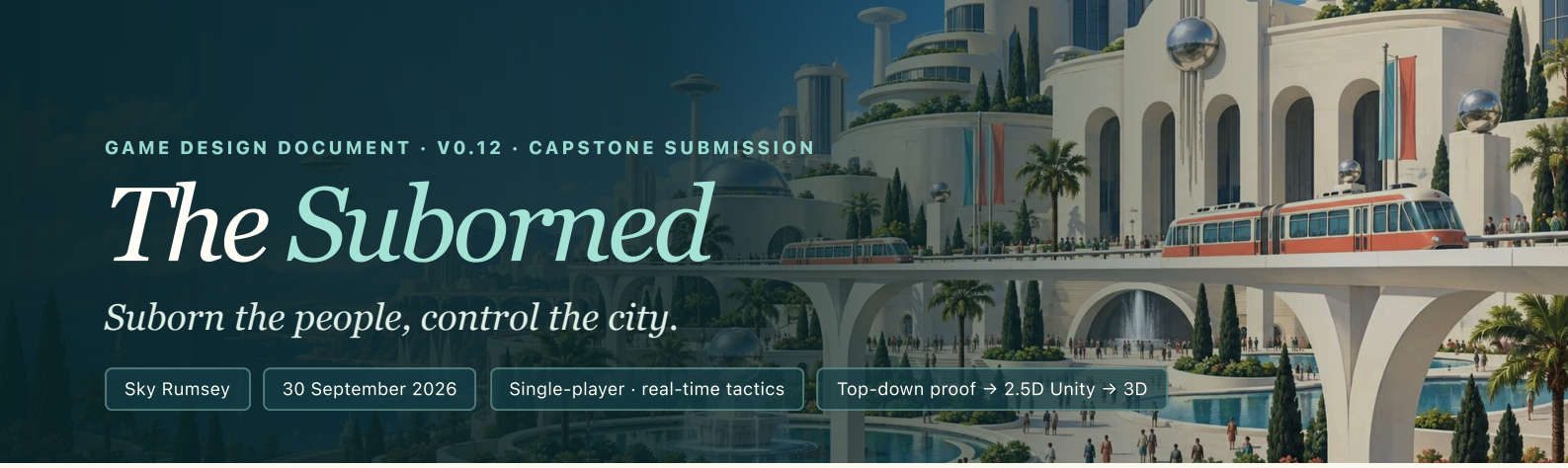


GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · V0.12 · CAPSTONE SUBMISSION

The Suborned

Suborn the people, control the city.

Sky Rumsey | 30 September 2026 | Single-player · real-time tactics | Top-down proof → 2.5D Unity → 3D

01 EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A city you take one person at a time

Progress comes from understanding people well enough to ask them for something they can actually do.

Premise. In *The Suborned*, a city carries out your plan without knowing it. A waitress spills a coffee, a guard steps away, a driver takes a different street: each does one small thing for their own reasons, and only you see the whole. They are the Suborned, and you lead the covert cell that turns them, in a bright retro-future city whose clean trams and civic towers hide clearance orders, informants and debts. It starts with one favour. By the end, whole streets block the police and crowds fight at your signal. Everyone you turned remembers how, and the city decides whether you are its heroes or its menace.

GENRE	CAMERA	MISSION	RUNTIME
Real-time tactics with tactical pause; single-player; PC	Fixed tactical view, above the street, never first person	One block, one objective, 8–12 minutes on a live clock	Fixed rules on generated people and missions; no AI during play

PILLAR 1

Subvert people

Learn what someone wants and how they are wired, then make an offer that fits. *Test: does knowing more make them cheaper, quieter or more loyal?*

PILLAR 2

Orchestrate the city

Combine contacts, routines and machines into a timed window, and later into a street that rises on cue. *Test: can the player see the window coming?*

PILLAR 3

Live with it

Every method leaves a trace, a reputation and a relationship that grows braver or more bitter. *Test: will the player meet this choice again?*

Act I · One person	Act II · Networks	Act III · Districts
The Fixer works alone: turn individuals, recruit the cell, build the first sources of income.	Contacts introduce contacts. Take over a workplace. Brave contacts fight beside you.	Streets rise or obey on cue, depending on your reputation. Institutions and rivals field squads.

> **Signature moment.** In training you cleared Inez's debt. Over three missions she grows braver, and in the fourth she drives the getaway car through a police cordon. In another playthrough you threatened her instead. She obeyed, grew more resentful, and in the fourth mission she is the one who tipped off the police.

Who it's for

Players who enjoy planning, timing and stories that come out of the systems: Syndicate's squad command, Desperados III's and Shadow Tactics' timing, Deus Ex's layered routes and Watch Dogs: Legion's city of people. Hero and Menace campaigns turn different people, so a second playthrough has a different cast.

Tiebreakers

- **Readable over rich:** the player always sees who saw what, what it cost and what changed.
- **People over powers:** access comes through people with motives.
- **Preparation beats improvisation**, in stealth and in a fight.
- **Commander, not avatar.** Exteriors only.

PROVEN

The top-down playtest runs Handover's routes, costs, rivals, fights and debrief. 28 scenario tests pass.

CAPSTONE

Rebuild that proof as a 2.5D Unity scene in five weeks.

LATER

Campaign systems beyond the capstone.

Since v0.9.18, agent review, a peer and the course instructor moved the focus from the build to the game. Changelog · ADD

02 GAME MECHANICS

Watch, turn, time, take

Each operative owns one verb. What you learn changes the price, and your reputation changes who will listen.

Watch → **Learn** → **Turn** → **Time** → **Take** → **Fight** → **Inherit**

SCOUT

Watch · Listen · Mislead. Reveals routines, needs and temperament. Sends rivals after false tips.

FIXER

Turn · Call. Pays, helps or threatens, then calls contacts in at the right moment.

TECH

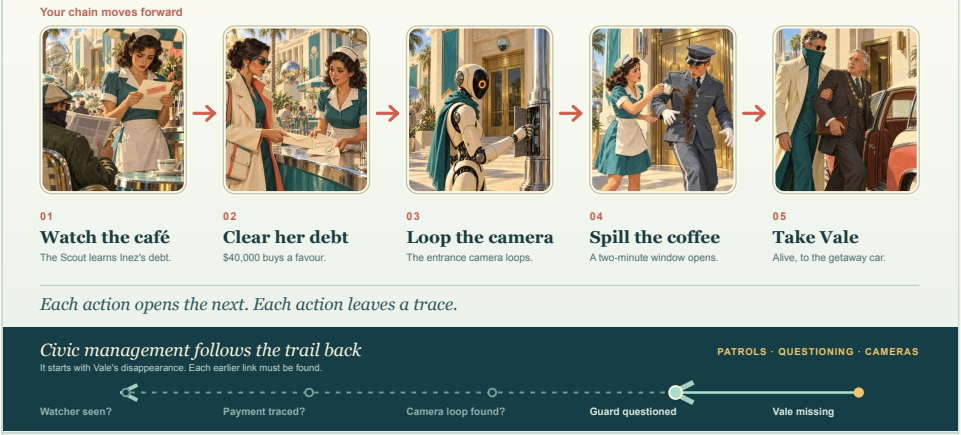
Loop · Reroute. Blinds surveillance and misdirects patrols, but stays tethered while the loop holds.

ENFORCER

Enter · Take · Fire. The only operative who carries the target or shoots.

A chain nobody else sees CAPSTONE

Even the training mission is a chain. Each person thinks they are solving their own problem; only you see the whole, and the city then works backward from the result, one link at a time. Later operations chain more links across a district.



Handover, route A. The trail back comes later.

Four ways to turn someone PROVEN

APPROACH (INEZ)	REQUIRES	CASH	TIME	TRAIL	WHAT IT LEAVES
Ask cold	Nothing	$0	25 s	+1	A remembered refusal. Later offers cost +$10,000 and +1 Trail.
Pay	Routine known (Watch, 52 s)	$70,000	50 s	+2	A traceable payment. The relationship stays neutral.
Help (clear her debt)	Need known (Listen, 42 s)	$40,000	50 s	+1	Gratitude. Her bravery can grow.
Pressure (threaten)	Need known	$0	35 s	+3	Fear. Her resentment grows, and she can identify the Fixer.

Finding things out pays for a second route: pay plus turning the driver costs $110,000 against a $100,000 purse, while help plus the driver costs $80,000.

Pressure PROVEN

Scheduled events never wait: guard routines, a rival crew and closing events such as the shift handover. **Alert** (0–3) is security's response now: 1 inquiry, 2 search, 3 lockdown, with each incident counted once. **Trail** is evidence the city follows into later missions. Each shot costs +1 Alert and +2 Trail and draws rivals. Witnesses are anyone with a clear view within 13 m. **Investigators** on foot and in cars question civilians. Each useful answer gives a place and a time, so you watch them follow the trail to you. Keep moving, reach witnesses first, or mislead them. LATER

Orders and readability CAPSTONE

Click selects or moves, Shift groups, 1–4 picks an operative; E engages, F fires, C calls. Clicking a person, door or camera opens its action card with cash, time, Trail and Alert shown before you commit. Pause to give orders; **Next Event** jumps to the next scheduled change. Dossiers show only what the cell has found.

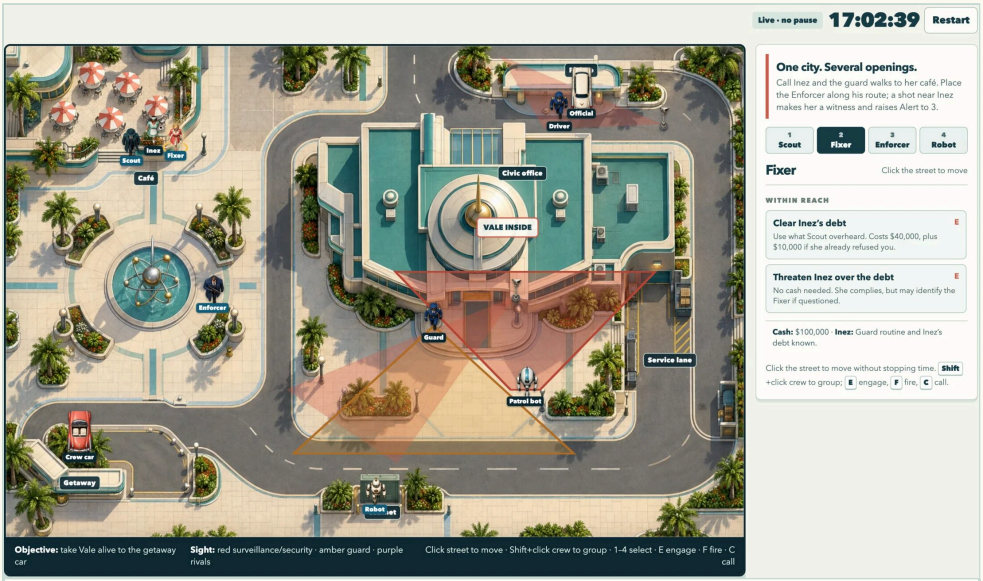
Resources. Cash buys people, **Arms** win fights and **Assets** (turned people) provide access, income and allies. Turned people pay out every mission: a clerk skims cash, a quartermaster diverts arms. Resources turn more people, and more people produce more resources. That compounding is the snowball. LATER

03

TRAINING MISSION · THE CAPSTONE

Handover

Councillor Vale signed the clearance order for the marked block. At shift handover he leaves the Civic Records Office. Take him alive to the getaway car. Full cell, $100,000 purse.



The top-down test in play at 2:39. The Scout has learned Inez's debt, so the Fixer's action cards show what each approach costs. Red cones are surveillance and security, amber is the guard, violet the rivals.

Schedule PROVEN

0:00 Vale inside. The guard, cameras and patrol run their routines.

3:10 The rival car parks near the pickup.

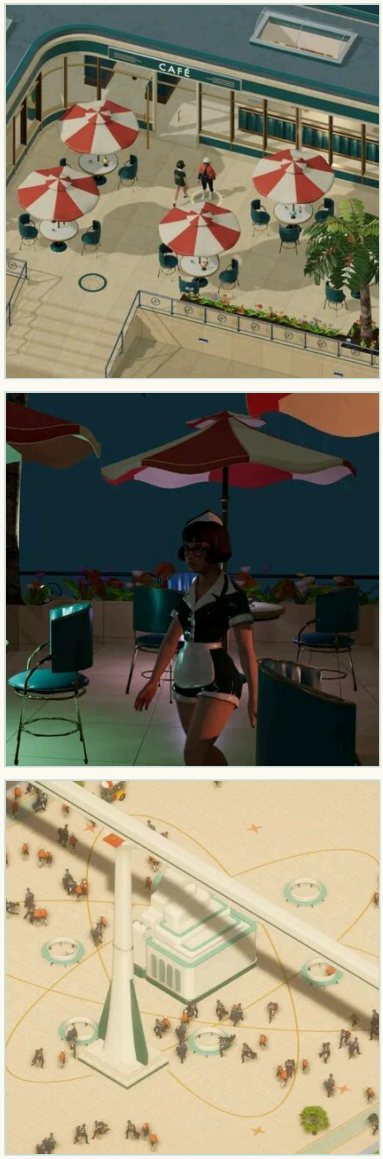
5:40 Last chance to turn the driver.

5:50 Vale leaves by the north door, or the service lane if the driver was turned.

8:00 Rivals take Vale, or his car leaves. The mission is over.

Win: Vale reaches the getaway car alive. **Fail:** Vale is killed · he leaves in the official car · rivals reach him · the district seals · the Enforcer goes down · the entry is seen.

> **Why the cast is fixed here.** Handover's people and timings were produced by the AI-built prototype and are frozen as the *reference case*: the mission generator (page 5) has to reproduce a mission of this quality, and the mission checker has to pass it.



In the browser build: the café from the tactical camera and Inez at street level (the view a payoff cut uses). In Unity: a crowded plaza.

A · Front door (before 5:50)

Scout learns Inez's debt (1:34) → Fixer clears it ($40,000) → Tech loops the entrance camera (1:02) → Inez calls the guard away, opening a **2:00** window (*payoff cut*) → Enforcer enters (38 s) and leaves by the service exit.

B · The pickup (from 5:50)

Scout finds that the driver needs cash (48 s) → Fixer turns him before 5:40 ($40,000), or has him park across the camera for 2:30 → Scout plants a false tip on the rivals (44 s) → Enforcer intercepts Vale (38 s).

The final fight: your approach picks your enemy CAPSTONE

YOU WENT LOUD

Any shot fired, or Alert 2 or higher. **The police** arrive with 2–4 officers from the west street and the seal clock is running. There are no allies: the guard is down or against you.

YOU PLAYED IT SAFE

The rival crew ambushes the extraction, 3–5 of them, for 30–60 s. The guard, who never saw you, defends his post against them. A helped Inez warns you 10 s early. A turned driver blocks one rival. The false tip cost them another.

04 FIGHTS AND CAMPAIGN

The test of how much of the city is yours

Fights grow as you rise. They measure your preparation: arms bought, brave contacts, and streets that pick a side.

Temperament × reputation LATER

TEMPERAMENT	AS HEROES	AS A MENACE
Idealist	Volunteers, grows brave fast	Refuses, may report you
Mercenary	Overcharges you	Discount, but sells you out
Fearful	Needs Help twice	Folds instantly, for free
Loyal	Turns after repeated Help	Reports any approach

Standing (Hero ↔ Menace) is tracked per district and moves only on *witnessed* acts. Neither end loses: heroes gain loyal crowds and fewer fights, while a menace turns people faster but faces betrayal and more fights.

Braver or more bitter LATER

Helped contacts climb from **Informant** to **Helper**, **Accomplice** and **Fighter**, one step per job where they aren't exposed. **Coerced** contacts go from **Compliant** to **Resentful** to **Informer**, who sells a route and sets up an ambush. Fear and resentment also make anyone a **Talker**: questioned, they give you up unless bravery and loyalty outweigh it. Between missions, contacts can be promoted, arrested or introduce a friend.

Objectives vary: a kidnapping, a bank job built on a planted teller, a killing by a manipulated proxy, a takeover won through a ruined reputation. Direct force always works, with a bigger trail.

Escalation LATER

- **How often:** Heat (campaign Trail + Menace standing) crosses thresholds that schedule a raid, ambush or rival hit. No dice.
- **How big:** set by the act, 3–6 → 8–15 → 20–30 hostiles. Hard cap of **30 simulated combatants**. The rest of the crowd only runs or cheers.
- **Your side:** the cell, Accomplice and Fighter contacts, and crowd joiners at Hero standing, armed up to your Arms stock.

Syndicate-style fights LATER

Everyone has health: civilian 2, guard or rival 3, patrol unit 4, operative 4, Enforcer 6. Weapons bought with Arms set damage and fire rate. A downed operative is carried out or captured. **Anyone can be shot, civilians included.** Every witness talks, and a contact who sees it grows afraid or bitter: some turn, more talk. It is the quickest way to undo everything you've built.

PROVEN Each shot adds +1 Alert and +2 Trail and draws rivals. Shooting the target fails the mission.

What citizens can do in a fight LATER

Scatter	Block	Join	Vehicle strike
Panic that breaks sightlines and covers a retreat.	Park a lorry, stall a tram or fill a street to stop the police.	Fight unarmed, or armed if you have the Arms.	Ram a barricade or send a rigged vehicle. The driver always jumps clear.

Content line. Civilians are never the payload. A coerced driver with a bomb is a suicide attack: a rating, store and press problem, and not the game's tone. The Menace version can be uglier, but no civilian dies as the weapon.

Wounds carry over. Health doesn't reset between missions. A turned doctor heals the cell quickly. Without one, finding a doctor becomes an objective of its own, if the city's calendar leaves time before the main mission. Go in hurt, go in short-handed, or spend the days: it's a choice in a living city. LATER

The decisive shot LATER: once or twice per fight, time slows and the camera drops behind the Enforcer for one aimed shot. No first-person firefights: they would lose the overview just when the city fights for you.

The debrief writes the next mission PROVEN

OUTPUT	STATES	COMPUTED FROM
Public security	Calm → Raised → High	Final Alert, and whether any shot was fired
Investigation	Little evidence → Early → Active (named cause)	Trail 0 / 1–2 / 3+, with named witnesses taking precedence
Assets	e.g. *Inez can introduce café contacts · Inez may identify the Fixer*	How each contact was turned, and what they saw
Standing, bravery, Heat LATER	Per district and per contact	Witnessed acts, completed jobs, pressure used

Replay freely before **Continue**. After that the result stands, and replays are practice only.

05

AI ARCHITECTURE · BUILD-TIME STUDIO

One lead, clear owners, generated content

Fifteen jobs, each held by a named Anima agent: the job says what they do, and the name is the agent's identity across projects. Aster, the lead, manages the rest; Sky is the only human integrator. What each agent receives at spawn, with its role card, is in the **agentic design document (ADD)**.

JOB	ANIMA AGENT	OWNS	MODEL
Lead and producer	**Aster**	Goals, this GDD, assigning work, decision log	Opus 5.5
Systems designer	**Motive**	Temperament, approach and standing rules	Opus 5.5
Mission designer	**Waymark**	Mission generator and checker	Opus 5.5
Dialogue designer	**Fable**	Dialogue generator keyed to person states	GPT 6.1 Sol
Simulation engineer	**Keel**	The shared rulebook and test scenarios	Opus 5.5
Unity engineer	**Latch**	Integration and builds	Opus 5.5
Schedule and AI designer	**Pulse**	Schedules, crowds and fight AI	GPT 6.1 Sol
Tools engineer	**Splice**	Checking tools	GPT 6.1 Sol
Environment artist	**Vela**	2.5D scenes	GPT 6.1 Sol
Character artist and animator	**Forma**	People, rigs and animation	GPT 6.1 Sol
Lighting artist	**Glint**	Matching live 3D to the painted scene	GPT 6.1 Sol
Interface artist	**Glyph**	HUD, dossier and signal colours	GPT 6.1 Sol
Audio designer	**Chime**	Cues and mix	GPT 6.1 Sol
Playtest and QA lead	**Suture**	Uncoached playtests, repro reports	Opus 5.5
Code and performance reviewer	**Redline**	Code review and profiling	Opus 5.5

Assess → **Assign** → **Review** → **Continue**

Every handoff says what goes in, what counts as done and who is next. **One rulebook for everyone:** Keel keeps a single list of everything that can happen in the city, and all missions, schedules and dialogue are checked against it before they reach Unity. Aster handles routine choices and escalates to Sky only for a pillar change, new paid spend, release, destructive action or an unresolved conflict.

Tool routing

TOOL	OWNERS	USE AND HANDOFF
Runware	Environment, characters, lighting, interface, audio	Images and audio from briefs. Each run is priced first; the chosen result goes to the next owner.
Blender	Environment, characters, lighting	Simple 3D shapes and people at game scale, handed to Latch. Blender is for previews; Unity is where it's judged.
Unity	Unity engineer (owner); tools, lighting, QA	Bring in checked content, run the checks and play the build. Only the Unity engineer edits scenes.

Nothing hand-authored, everything checked LATER

CONTENT	GENERATED FROM	CHECKED BY
People	Occupation × temperament × need × relationships × routine	Automatic checks: every person can reach their places and has one clear need
Missions	A template (objective, target, closing event, fight trigger) filled with district people	The **mission checker**, which plays it in the simulation
Dialogue, portraits, voices	Each person's data and state (brave, bitter, promoted), produced at build time	Tone and rating filters, plus sampled review

> **The mission checker.** A generated mission ships only if at least two quiet routes win, a loud route exists and costs more Trail, every way to fail can actually happen, no single contact is essential, and a player who knows everything finishes with a minute to spare. **No AI runs during play:** the same choices always give the same result.

The risk is sameness. Watch Dogs: Legion shows that when everyone can be recruited, nobody stands out. The fix is **history, not backstory**: people become memorable through what the systems record with you. Generated text is only a thin layer on top.

06 TECHNICAL STRATEGY

Prove the rules small, then dress them

The rules live apart from the engine, so the same rules run in the browser test, in 2.5D Unity and later in 3D.

Events drive everything. A guard leaving, a contact answering, a shot: each is an event with its conditions, effects and witnesses. Any run can be replayed exactly from its starting state and the player's orders. Unity shows the rules; it doesn't own them.

Same results in Unity. Unity must pass the same 28 scenarios as the browser prototype before any content goes in.

Performance is judged by frame rate at play zoom, not polygon counts.

Biggest constraint: keeping fifteen agents consistent. A handoff can look right yet give a person an action or a door the mission doesn't have. The shared rulebook stops that: Splice's tools reject anything not in it, Suture replays runs to confirm the results, and Aster settles conflicts before anything goes into the game.

Capstone plan (five weeks)

WEEK	DELIVERABLE	EXIT CHECK
1	Rules proven in the top-down test	Two routes win, and going loud fails at a cost DONE
2	The rules move into Unity; Handover laid out in the 2.5D scene	28 scenarios pass in Unity
3	Cell control, contacts, security, rivals; readability pass	First uncoached playtest
4	Final fight (both branches), payoff cut, dossier, event log, debrief	New-player test; freeze the rules
5	Tuning, fixes, audio cues. No new systems.	Final uncoached gate

> **Gate.** An uncoached player can state the objective and fail conditions, choose an approach because of something they learned, explain its cost, complete a chain, say why they fought police rather than rivals (or the reverse), and read what the next mission inherits. **If the schedule slips, cut in this order:** crowd witnesses → patrol reroute → camera-block variant → the police branch. Always keep both routes, the payoff cut, the debrief and the gate.

Budget · estimates; measured usage replaces them from week 2

ITEM	PLAN
Planning and review	About 88.8k tokens per pass (from the v0.9 estimate) × 5 weekly passes ≈ 0.44M
Coding and integration	Within two existing 20× subscriptions (one Codex, one Claude); usage tracked per account; Aster checks capacity before assigning work and drops optional work
Paid tools	Runware and Meshy priced per run before use (a rigged Meshy citizen is about 35 credits)
Generation	None in the capstone (Handover is fixed); measured on the first generator run

Presentation

The capstone is a **static 2.5D scene with 3D projection**. Buildings are painted; people, vehicles, doors, cameras and barricades are live 3D. Target character height is 40–60 px at 1080p. Cones are security red, the guard amber and rivals violet, colours no environment surface uses. **One payoff cut**: when Inez's distraction lands, cut briefly to street level.

Audio is part of the clock

Routines you can hear (a bell, the café door, a handover chime at 5:30). Security warns before it acts (a camera click, the patrol's tone changing). Alert adds layers to the music, a fight brings in the full score, and contacts confirm calls aloud.

Risks and what keeps them small

COMBAT FEEL

Fights and combat animation are the hardest part, and the rigs only walk and run so far. Capped at 30 simulated combatants, vehicles follow lanes, and the capstone fight is scripted and short.

SAMENESS

Generated people can blur together. Memory, bravery and resentment create history, the mission checker rejects weak missions, and a recall test checks that players remember contacts.

ONE INTEGRATOR

Agents speed up code and assets, but not playtesting or integration. Only work that serves the gate is integrated; there are no interiors and no first-person play.